



As the last of the steam dissipated, Maarika and Tisket found themselves facing a huge golden cat with folded wings. It sat with its enormous front paws extended, one crossed over the other. The cat's body was topped by a woman's head with tawny skin, large golden eyes, and thick hair hanging in plaits on either side of its face.

"It's a sphinx," Maarika said.

"Well, hack it!" Gibraltar said. "We're running out of time."

"But it's a *sphinx*," Maarika said. "I can't hack a sphinx!"

"Initiating riddle sequence," the sphinx said, slowly blinking its eyes.

"Oh, this is fine, everything is just fine," Tisket said.

The sphinx unfolded its paws and spoke. "The more you take, the more you leave behind. What are they?"

"This is not my area of expertise," Maarika said. "Uh, breaths? No. Time?" More boots thudded down the hallway, and Maarika's beautiful face brightened. "Footsteps!"

"Security code one accepted," said the sphinx. "What disappears the moment you say its name?"

"Silence!" Maarika immediately answered.

The sphinx lifted one paw and flexed it to briefly display its claws. "A man jumps off a bridge. What color is the bridge?"

